



PURPOSE, GOALS & MOTIVATION

Finding direction, setting meaningful goals, and keeping going when motivation changes.



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Purpose gives direction. Goals turn that direction into steps. Motivation can help us begin, but it naturally rises and falls. For students and young people, building a meaningful path is often less about having everything figured out and more about learning what matters, taking the next step, and adjusting along the way.

WHY PURPOSE MATTERS

Purpose is the sense that what you are doing connects to something meaningful. It does not have to be a perfect career plan or one grand life mission. Purpose can grow from your values, relationships, interests, strengths, service to others, learning, or the kind of person you want to become.

THOUGHTS TO WATCH FOR

- “I should already know exactly what I want.”
- “If I change my goal, I have failed.”
- “Everyone else has their life figured out.”
- “If I am not motivated, I am lazy.”

“You do not need the whole map. You need a meaningful next step.”

PURPOSE IS BUILT, NOT ALWAYS DISCOVERED

Many students feel pressure to identify one perfect purpose early. In reality, purpose can become clearer through experience. Trying a project, volunteering, learning a skill, meeting people, or working on a problem you care about can reveal what matters to you.

01

NOTICE WHAT MATTERS TO YOU

Pay attention to the issues, people, activities, and values that consistently hold your attention.

02

IDENTIFY YOUR STRENGTHS

Think about what you do well, what others trust you with, and what skills you want to develop.

03

CONNECT PURPOSE TO ACTION

Choose one small activity that lets you practice what matters to you rather than waiting for certainty.

04

ALLOW YOUR DIRECTION TO CHANGE

A changed goal does not automatically mean failure. New experiences can change what you value or pursue.

GOALS TURN DIRECTION INTO SOMETHING YOU CAN PRACTICE

A goal becomes more useful when it is specific enough to guide your next action. Instead of “I want to succeed,” try “I will update my CV this week,” “I will study for one hour after class,” or “I will contact two people working in a field I am exploring.”

A SIMPLE WAY TO SET BETTER GOALS

Goals do not have to be huge to matter. Start with what is important, make it concrete, and give yourself a realistic next step.

START WITH WHY	What makes this goal meaningful to you?
MAKE IT SPECIFIC	What exactly will you do, and what would progress look like?
MAKE IT SMALL ENOUGH TO START	What can you do in the next 24 hours or this week?
SET A CHECK-IN	Choose a time to review what worked, what did not, and what needs changing.

WHEN GOALS FEEL OVERWHELMING

Break the goal into the smallest useful action. If applying for jobs feels overwhelming, begin by listing three roles. If studying feels impossible, choose one topic for the next 25 minutes. Progress often becomes easier to see when the task is small enough to begin.

“Small steps are still movement.”

A HEALTHIER WAY TO TALK TO YOURSELF

Instead of...	Try...
“I am behind.”	“My path has its own timing, and I can focus on my next step.”
“I need to feel motivated first.”	“I can begin with a small action even when motivation is low.”
“If I change direction, I failed.”	“I can learn from what I tried and adjust.”

MOTIVATION WILL NOT ALWAYS FEEL THE SAME

Motivation can be affected by stress, tiredness, disappointment, uncertainty, workload, and life changes. That does not mean your goals no longer matter. A sustainable approach combines motivation with routines, support, and manageable action.

01

CREATE ROUTINES

Decide when and where a small action will happen instead of relying entirely on how you feel.

02

TRACK PROGRESS

Keep a simple list of completed actions. Visible progress can make a long journey easier to recognize.

03

REST WITHOUT GUILT

Rest is part of sustaining effort. Recovery can help you return with more capacity.

04

ASK FOR SUPPORT

Talk to a trusted friend, mentor, lecturer, colleague, or support person when you feel stuck.

05

RECONNECT WITH YOUR WHY

When motivation fades, remind yourself why the goal matters and whether the goal still fits your values.

REMEMBER

Your purpose does not have to be perfectly defined before you start. Goals can be revised. Motivation can return. A slower season does not erase the progress you have already made.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Use these questions to turn reflection into action. You do not have to answer everything today.

1. What matters most to me at this stage of my life?

2. What kind of person do I want to become?

3. What strengths do I want to develop?

4. What is one goal that would move me closer to the life I want?

5. What is the smallest useful action I can take this week?

6. Who can encourage, guide, or hold me accountable?

7. What will I do when my motivation is low?

YOUR LIFE DOES NOT HAVE TO LOOK LIKE SOMEONE ELSE'S TO HAVE MEANING.

Purpose can grow. Goals can change. Motivation can fluctuate. What matters is that you keep learning, choosing, and taking meaningful steps.

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